

Acknowledgments

I would like to thank my tutor, Matthew Flinders, for his help in guiding this project and providing advice, and in particular for challenging me to push myself. I would also like to thank my friend and neighbour Hayden for helping me through the long days of lockdown.

'You say you'll change the constitution
Well, you know
We all want to change your head
You tell me it's the institution
Well, you know
You better free you mind instead
But if you go carrying pictures of chairman Mao
You ain't going to make it with anyone anyhow'

Revolution (1968)
Lennon/McCartney
The Beatles

'All the stories have been told
Of kings and days of old,
But there's no England now.
All the wars that were won and lost
Somehow don't seem to matter very much anymore.
All the lies we were told,
All the lies of the people running round,
They're castles have burned.
Now I see change,
But inside we're the same as we ever were.
...
Now another leader says
Break their hearts and break some heads.
Is there nothing we can say or do?
Blame the future on the past,
Always lost in blood and guts.
And when they're gone, it's me and you.'

Living on a Thin Line (1984)
Dave Davies
The Kinks

All the world's a stage,
And all the men and women merely players;

Act II, Scene VII
As You Like It (c. 1599)
William Shakespeare

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Abstract:

Populism has been a largely misunderstood phenomena in Britain. While the rise of UKIP in the early 2010s was an important part of this populist growth, the victory of populist leadership candidates within the Labour and Conservative parties has been underexplored. The strong two-party system in Britain has resulted in populism rising in the existing party system rather than outside it. This dissertation argues that this 'British exceptionalism' needs to be reconsidered when analysing the uniqueness of British populism within both the populist and party literature. By comparing the rise of Jeremy Corbyn in the 2015 Labour Party leadership election and Boris Johnson in the 2019 Conservative Party election, a model of intra-party populism emerges. This dissertation makes three core arguments: populism is largely an intra-party phenomenon in Britain; populism focuses on both changing the party and the nation; and the opening up the leadership elections is the primary cause.

Keywords: intra-party populism, Conservative Party, Labour Party.

British Intra-Party Populism: Living on a Thin Line

Introduction

The decade of austerity in the 2010s has had the most profound implications on the political makeup of Britain since at least the victory of Margaret Thatcher in 1979. The growth of populism and anti-politics has fuelled a distrust of politics and politicians in both the electorate and in the political parties. The most talked about result of this growth was the vote to leave the European Union in 2016, however it is in the growth of populism as an intra-party phenomenon that already begun by 2015 where perhaps the most significant changes in British politics can be found.

The victory of intra-party populists in Britain, with Jeremy Corbyn as Labour leader in 2015 and Boris Johnson Conservative Party in 2019, represents a profound shift in British political parties. This dissertation will carry out a comparison into the rise of populism as an intra-party phenomenon.

Populism is not well defined, however numerous commonalities exists: all populists try and define a style of politics that aims to usurp the dominance of 'mainstream' politics. Furthermore, there is a strong focus on leadership and the party leader; with populists aiming to highlight the purity and disenfranchisement of their 'people' either in moral, cultural or economic terms. Both Labour and Conservative Party's faced populist challenges to the dominance of the 'governing party elites' (MPs, high-level bureaucrats, prominent ex-MPs) that had existed in both parties, caused by the opening up of party leadership election.

In 2015 the Labour Party elected Jeremy Corbyn following a change to voter leadership selection methods from an electoral college of MPs, Unions, and members; to a OMOV (One Member One Vote) system, where only members chose the leader. In the Conservative Party, there were milder reforms but still substantial, allowing party members the final say on a choice of two candidates selected by the Parliamentary Party.

This dissertations core argument is that populism should be largely considered in this way, through the party system and structure. This intra-party phenomenon in Britain was first developed by Watts and Bale who said 'it is rare' (2018; 100) to study populism from an intra-party perspective. This dissertation goes further, arguing that populism in Britain is a much misunderstood phenomenon and should primarily be looked at from this intra-party perspective.

This model of 'British exceptionalism' sets it apart from the study of broader populisms around the world, which seem populism as an inter-party phenomenon, resulting in analysis too often focused on the rise of already established populist parties. Using an intra-party model, this dissertation will explain how populist sentiment and different political styles were used in two instances of a party leadership election to gain a better understanding on populism as an intra-party phenomenon. In order to do this both the literature on parties and party leadership will be combined to better conceptualise an intra-party populist model.

While this 'intra-party' model is the core of this dissertation, there are four other key arguments this dissertation seeks to make to the study of British populism and the populist literature:

- Intra-party populism focuses on both changing the party as well as the nation;
- The structure of the Labour and Conservative parties have changed, making it easier for a populist upsurge within parties, something that may become a recurring theme in future elections;
- Populism in Britain is as much about political style as ideology;
- 'Who is a populist' is not a binary divide. The relationship between being popular and an employer of populist tactics is not as clear as the broader literature suggests.

Methods

This dissertation will take a discursive approach to the comparison, by tracing how and why the two main parties in Britain elected populist leaders for the first time in their histories at similar times. By discussing the election of Johnson and Corbyn, and the background of party reforms and the changing leadership election rules, the two case studies will highlight the need to further study populism in Britain using the conceptual framework of *Intra-Party Populism*. Areas like party leadership and the leadership selection, have not been combined to any degree in understanding the nature of intra-party populism. By using this approach, this dissertation aims to highlight the unique nature of British populism in relation to the populist literature at large.

There are several important pieces of literature this dissertation attempts to use as departure points. The first is Watts and Bale (2018) and their work on intra-party populism within the Labour Party. The second is Moffit's (2017) influential conception of populism as a political ideology and

degradations of populisms. The third and fourth pieces of literature are Stark's (1996) analysis of party leadership and party selection, and Denham, Dorey and Roe Crines (2020) history of party leadership. This dissertation aims to supplement the literature by providing a coherent framework around which all four pieces of literature can rest.

The author would like also like to note that due to COVID-19 restrictions, no interviews were able to be carried out for this dissertation and there was only online access to the library, leading to a heavy reliance on journal articles.

Chapter 1: Populism

The populist literature is a highly fraught and contested arena, with debate ongoing as to define populism (Laclau, 1977; Taggart, 2000). Some argue the term populism should be removed as a term from political literature all together (Barr, 2009). However a proliferation of literature over the past 20 years pays testament to the rising levels of support for politics - demonstrating the importance the study of populism has to offer scholars in understanding political discontent.

Yet this broader inability to define populism may not however be as problematic as first imagined. Populists and populism is changing constantly, reflecting the changing world more rapidly than mainstream politics. In Britain this rising populist sentiment was challenged through Corbyn's aims to restore representative institutions to the populous (Molyneux and Osborne, 2017; Wellings and Vines, 2015) and Johnson's more traditional populist approach focusing on the European Union and the 'left behind', especially in Northern England (Flinders, 2020).

The recognition that populism as a taxonomical definition has been stretched however is not new, with Ionescu and Gellner asking in 1969 'is there one phenomenon corresponding to this one name' (Ionescu and Gellner: 1969, 1). Yet there are some starting points. Mudde's (2007; 23) often quoted definition serves as a marker in the literature, he labels populism as a 'thin-centred ideology that considers society to be ultimately separated into two homogenous and antagonistic groups, the "pure people," versus the "corrupt elite," which argues that politics should be an expression of the *volonte generale* (general will) of the people.' Mudde's definition has gained significant traction, however labelling populism an 'ideology' suggests they share basic ideas. Populists rarely share any firm ideology: it is less an ideology and more an approach to politics. In Britain, Corbyn's political style of 'populism wearing a cardigan' compares to Johnsonian 'clowning' (Flinders, 2020). In many populisms there is an ideology, however this ideology is ever changing, while populisms can have some similar and some different aims.

Mudde's theory of populism as an ideology has received much comment and argument with Moffitt (2017) being the first to highlight the need to see populism more as a political style, where leaders use meditated performance to navigate the corridors of power that include the political, along with an ability to stretch their message into everyday life. Yet Moffitt himself agrees that there are recognized populists who do not match this 'style' yet are still considered populist: Alberti Fujimori,

Preston Manning, Pauline Hanson and Jeremy Corbyn (Moffitt, 2017; 62; Barr, 2009; Watts and Bale, 2018). Yet, Moffitt arguably underplays his own theory. Political style does not have to involve an overt use of oratory or rhetoric. Corbyn was not a great speaker or a 'strong man', but a strong image of how he saw himself, and his self-styled politics of a 'downtrodden comrade' was a prominent part of his appeal. Populist styling can be more subtle than Moffitt originally suggested.

One area Moffitt's conception of political style does not explain fully is how this relates to 'the people'. Populists emphasise 'the people' as one homogenous group with a similar discontent with the system. This populist focus on 'the people' is one of the few areas of populism where there is broad agreement (Canovan, 1984) - though 'the people' is perhaps more accurately rendered as 'my people' (Saward, 2010). Despite a central focus on 'the people' there is little understanding of how 'the people' work and how to understand them (Arditi, 2007; Canovan, 2005). This lack of understanding may be understandable, as Benedict Anderson's concept of an 'imagined community' gives a clue as to why a true understanding of 'the people' has not yet been forthcoming. Populists have to create a community and create a message of some grievance with the system.

Many politicians play up to this conceptual, if not actual, understanding of 'the people' and what they want, despite no such community being as homogenous as they imagine (van Zoonen, 2012). It is therefore a populists job to create this community through political styling, mediatization, charisma, and the exploitation of crises. Broadly speaking, populists aim to speak on behalf of the 'people' through the media (Simons, 2002) and place 'the people' at the centre of a system which populists claim, does not work for them.

Yet in terms of this dissertation, it is the focus on 'the leader' where populism begins to find its intra-party form. Populism rarely works as an inert force applying political pressure on the system, especially in a representative party system. The leader provides a conduit of populist anger, either by representing the populist sentiment or driving it.

There is a deep focus within the literature on 'the leader', with some believing more in the importance of the leader than others. Weyland (2001) argues that populist leaders are the key figures in the movement, while others believe they only have a more symbolic relevance (Laclau, 2005). Meanwhile some argue leaders are less important still and choose to focus on the manifesto of parties and their electoral literature (Pauwels, 2011). Yet this is a controversial position, most scholars believe in this 'leader centric' view of populism.

Yet this different conception of how the political leader operates, can be explained by different political systems and different political cultures. As Moffitt states 'what is clear... is that the choice of whether one decides to focus on the leader, party, or movement...is heavily influenced by the case of region one is writing about' (Moffitt, 2017; 54). Britain, defined by its strong political culture of parties and Parliamentary politics is unlikely to see a Marine Le Pen style rise. Even UKIP, Respect and the BNP saw it difficult to gain a foothold in Westminster due to the First-Past-the-Post (FPTP) political system.

Those with an interest in the study of populism need to better understand different political models and cultures when analysing the rise of populism. In Britain, the use of the party and Parliamentary system is not well understood to its relationship to populism, compared to the more open political system with proportional or presidential systems like Europe or South America. The question remains, how did Corbyn, an obscure backbencher become elevated by populist sentiment within the Labour Party. Similarly, how Johnson – a troublemaker and populist - won, when in previous decades may have been eased aside by the Parliamentary Party.

This is where Barr's (2009) concept of political 'mavericks' will be instructive. Barr defines a maverick as a 'politician who rises to prominence within an established, competitive party but then either abandons his affiliation to compete as an independent or in association with an outsider party, or radically reshapes his own party' (ibid, 34). Both Johnson and Corbyn had long been inside politics and their parties (Corbyn a long time backbench MP; and Johnson MP and Mayor of London). However both held positions far enough away from the mainstream of the party to be considered different. Barr's political maverick concept answers how both Johnson and Corbyn were able to be 'insiders' and yet develop an 'outsider' rhetoric as part of their political style. Barr argues that populist mavericks 'credibly offer anti-establishment appeals and present themselves as agents of change' (ibid, 44).). In Barr's argument, populism is led by outsiders or mavericks to gain power using an anti-establishment rhetoric. Barr's argument is limited to Latin American populism, where insiders cast themselves as outsiders and subsequently leave the original party to form their own party. Yet the concept does not need much adjusting to see how the 'maverick' status of outsider can be successful inside the party structure.

Therefore, this dissertation's argument of intra-party populism is meant as an addition to the current literature in a field where Hackney (1971, xxii) states 'scholarly reassessment of populism will never

end.’ The broader study of populism in Britain often aims to replicate the European populist model with a focus on populist parties like UKIP and Respect (March, 2017; Steenbergen and Siczek, 2017). The introduction of a new way to investigate populism in Britain may help guide future literature. To do this, this dissertation will aim to understand the populism of Corbyn and Johnson in four primary ways.

Firstly, despite the constant invocation of ‘the people’, there has been little study of ‘the people’ (Arditi, 2007). There is a well understood concept of who the people are, but not how they operate (Moffitt, 2017). Studying parties in an intra-party manner allows a study of the membership, and how they too use populism and populist leaders in order to further their policy goals.

Secondly is the study of the relationship between political style and populism. Moffitt’s (2017) theory of political style is heavily reliant on focusing on the political style of populists, yet focusing on two leaders whose populism is as stylistic as it is ideological will provide more empirical evidence for this conception.

Thirdly is the nature of the ‘maverick’ in a strong party system, where ‘spinning off’ to form a new party is unlikely. Both Johnson and Corbyn were parliamentary insiders before casting themselves as outsiders. This dissertation will analyse how Corbyn and Johnson turned themselves from insiders into mavericks. There is a well-developed literature on populist leaders (see Moffitt, 2017; 51-69) yet little on this idea of the ‘maverick.’

Fourthly and most importantly is the nature of the British political system and populism. It has been observed that Britain’s relative absence of large scale populist parties in Britain has been down to the mainstream parties co-opting their populist politics (Mair, 2002; Mudde, 2004), while Britain’s FPTP electoral system has also been noted as a reason for Britain’s absence of populist parties (Mudde, 2007). Yet this co-opting of populist politics by leaders such as Thatcher and Tony Blair was mild. Britain has seen a surge of more concerted populism both inside and outside the mainstream in recent years. The rise of UKIP is well attested too (see Cutts, et al., 2019; Cutts, Ford and Goodwin, 2010; Steenbergen and Siczek, 2017) but by only focusing on inter-party models, it is of limited relevance to the UK. While UKIP’s success in European elections was significant, they have never returned more than one MP to Parliament. This narrow view of populism limits the understanding of Britain’s two main parties.

Chapter 2: Parties and leadership

The previous chapter discussed populism and how British populism should be conceived as different than Western Europe. This chapter will underline this difference by talking about the nature of the party and party leadership in Britain. It will highlight the role of party structure and the opening up of how British parties in allowing intra-party democracy, which sowed the seeds of change that a populist maverick could exploit. It will also highlight the relationship of party members to the party leader, which has become intrinsic in modern political parties in Britain with the opening up of party leadership elections in the 1990s and 2000s.

The study of party politics and intra-party conflict is often centred around Michel's Iron Law of Oligarchy (Michels, 1915). The Iron Law argues that in organisations, oligarchy will always occur even when an organisation is run in a non-hierarchical manner. This theory has often been treated as almost axiomatic within the study of organisations (Diefenbach, 2018). Yet there are occasions Diefenbach argues, when the Iron Law can be subverted, such as when 'aggrandisers and organisational psychopaths, powerful leaders or power elites emerge' (ibid, 558).

Michel's Iron Law is currently expressed through the cartel party thesis (Katz and Mair, 1995), which argues that the political system is dominated by cartel like parties; and Panebianco's (1988) theory which argues that parties have become professionalised and less in need of amateurs, 'i.e. party members' (Seyd, 2020; 2). Yet this leadership dominated view of parties is at odds with how parties are now ran. The two main parties have seen the party elites power loosen over the past 50 years. The first hint of this in Britain was the slow concentration of power around the leader and away from this previously polycentric power model.

There is a growing academic consensus that the party leader is the most important party figure. From the relative unimportance in Britain (Stewart and Clarke, 1992; Stark, 1996) to more modern scholarship (Garzia, D., Ferreira da Silva, F. and De Angelis, A, 2019; McAllister, 2013), which suggests the leader has much more power. Early party leaders were often figureheads with their primary function being able to command the support of their parliamentary party. This began to shift as mass communication resulted in the growth of the leader (Cross and Blais, 2011), not solely as a leader of the MPs, but the leader of the whole party (Stark, 1996).

With the dominance of the leader, selection of leaders became an increasingly vital role in determining the parties future. In the post-war years the Labour leader was elected only through a vote of the Parliamentary Party; while the Conservative Party's parliamentary leader was selected through what Stark called a 'magic circle' of Conservative grandees (Stark, 1996). The disastrous consequence of Douglas-Home's selection in 1963 pushed the Conservative Party leadership selection towards the Parliamentary Party and away from the magic circle. Labour began to increasingly think of the parliamentary leader as the party leader too, with changes in 1980s to make the Parliamentary Leader the party leader (Stark, 1996; 40). However the increasing importance of the party leader did not coincide with increasing democracy. The members previous only incentive to join was to select the local party representative. As party leaders moved from a position of *primus inter pares* (first among equals) in the parliamentary parties, and towards a clear position of authority it resulted in less overall intra-party democracy. However, due to demands from members there was a general push for more membership inclusion (Seyd, 2020, 3; Stark, 1996; Denham, Dorey and Roe-Crines, 2020).¹

Conservative Party Leadership election process

<i>Date</i>	<i>Democratic status</i>	<i>Role of party 'elites'</i>	<i>Role of Parliamentary Party</i>	<i>Role of membership</i>
<i>Pre-war - 1963</i>	Closed	Large	Nil	Nil
<i>1963</i>	Closed	Large	Small	Nil
<i>1965-1997</i>	Closed	Moderate	Large	Minimal
<i>1998-present</i>	Semi-open	Small	Large	Moderate

Table 1. Denham, Dorey, and Roe-Crines (2020)

¹ There is an interesting relationship between the Conservative Party post-Thatcher, and Labour post-Blair. Both parties have increasingly had problems finding broadly ideologically acceptable leaders; leading to the question of whether this growth of internal democracy for members has in part, been driven by an inability for party elites to decide 'what is next.'

Labour Party Leadership election process

<i>Date</i>	<i>Democratic status</i>	<i>Role of party 'elites'</i>	<i>Role of Parliamentary Party</i>	<i>Role of membership</i>	<i>Role of Unions</i>
<i>Pre-war -1981</i>	Closed	Moderate	Large	Nil	Nil
<i>1981-2012</i>	Semi-open	Small	Large	Small	Moderate
<i>2012-present</i>	Mostly open	Minimal	Moderate	Large	Nil

Table 2. Denham, Dorey, and Roe-Crines (2020)

Leonard Stark's 1996 *'Choosing a Leader'* was an influential analysis of party leadership and has seen much comment and scrutiny, yet has largely been accepted by the media in analysing British party leadership. However, some of Stark's analysis would look out of date in today's climate. Stark's claim that party leadership rules do not 'make different leaders' (Stark, 1996; 131) seems to go at odds to recent empirical evidence in the British political parties. Furthermore, Stark goes onto claim that 'different electorates appear to apply the same criteria when assessing leadership candidates' as the parliamentary party (ibid. 131). Quinn (2016, 768) was the first to spot this recent change stating 'Corbyn would not have won categorically if the selection rules were a purely Parliamentary Party vote or the electoral congress system.'

Table 3. Strategic concerns involved in party leadership contests (Stark, 1996; 126)

<i>Order</i>	<i>Arena</i>	<i>Goal</i>	<i>Criterion</i>
<i>1st</i>	Internal	Unity	Acceptability
<i>2nd</i>	Electoral	Victory	Electability
<i>3rd</i>	Parliamentary	Policy	Competence

This shift in who elects the party leader would be less important if the members and party elites voting incentives and desires were similar, as Stark suggests. Yet the difference between members

and elites was highlighted by May's (1973) law of curvilinear disparity. The theory argues parties are stratified with the elites and regular voters the least extreme, while the party activists or 'sub-leaders' inside the party are the politically more extreme. May's law has seen much debate in recent years with some seeing it as an out of date, arguing there is little significant difference between members' ideology and that of the elites, who can sometimes be more extreme than the membership (see Saglie and Heidar, 2004; Norris, 1995; Bale, 2018; Seyd and Whiteley, 2002).

However, May's law should perhaps be revaluated once again in light of Corbyn and Johnson. Inductively, Johnson and Corbyn were populist mavericks and therefore not the favoured candidates of the party elites. Suggesting it makes sense that May's Law of a more ideologically extreme membership would apply in 2015 and 2019 respectively. However, the deductive case for a reappraisal of May's Law is more persuasive. Katz (1990) argued many members found alternative routes for activism, making the more raucous members less likely to join parties, and nullifying May's Rule. In terms of the Labour Party, these results were borne out by Whiteley et al. (2018) who found radicalism and the chance to have a direct say in the Labour Party resulted in a growth of membership in and after 2015. Only 20 years previously, Seyd and Whitley (2002) found no serious difference between members and party elites in the Labour Party in the 1990s. Yet the increasing amount of research into the Labour membership has seen both a growth in numbers and a radicalisation (Crines, Jeffrey, Heppell, 2018). Furthermore, the growth of party membership after the change of the rules, was because these members wanted a new style of politics and more radical economic policies that party elites did not. This all suggests that May's Law is once again applicable and able to highlight what the opening up of the Labour Party would result in.

The Conservative Party is different, in that it's largely stable membership became more ideological over time, coinciding with the Brexit referendum and the rise of Johnson. Yet the same arguments still apply to the Conservative Party as to the Labour Party (See Chapter 4).

In their original thesis for the cartel party, Katz and Mair's (1995) laid out a series of possible challengers to the elite control of the party system. They argued the challengers would come from the 'Ross Perot' mould, or the 'new middle class' such as the Liberal Democrats (Katz and Mair, 1995; 24) and would challenge the oligarchy via new parties. What they did not account for was breaking of the oligarchy coming from within. Britain has a long history of stability with the main political parties being able to see off threats by adapting the existing party structure and co-opting policy positions, rather than accepting an outside challenger. Katz and Mair hypothesised how the

elite dominated party could change; this dissertation is arguing that change has occurred due to intra-party populism. The following two chapters will look at the rise of both Johnson and Corbyn

Chapter 3: The Labour Party

The victory of Jeremy Corbyn in the 2015 Labour Leadership election has been called ‘the most dramatic in parliamentary history’ (Quinn, 2016; 759). That a long-term backbencher became the leader of one of the two main parties in Britain is often seen as a surprise; yet relayed against a backdrop of rising political discontent against austerity and a concurrent weakening of party elites within the Labour Party’s intra-party democracy, it should be no surprise the ‘anti-hero for an anti-politics age’ (Parker and Pickard, 2015) became leader.

This chapter will argue the following:

- Corbyn’s populism was eccentric even for British standards. He was part symbol of the 1970s Labour left, part promiser of political change and part populist.
- His victory was due to the change in leadership selection.
- Many saw Corbyn promising a new Labour Party as appealing. Much of his early campaign was focused on populism within the party. Once he began to lead in the polls his message changed towards the country at-large.
- Corbyn was able to elevate his small movement by winning the leadership contest highlights intra-party populism as both an internal party mechanism to enact change within the party; and then to change this message towards the country at-large.

Labour Party Background

In order to fully actualise Corbyn’s rise, it is important to understand the Labour Party’s relationship to its left-wing. The left of the Labour Party has long tried and failed to gain more of a say within the overall party (Seyd, 1987) both through extra-party groups involving many Labour MP’s such as the Campaign for Nuclear Disarmament, and intra-party groups such as the Trotskyist ‘Militant’ group whose entryism caused alarm during the 1970s (Steffen, 1987).

With this lack of historical impact, it should come as little surprise that this wing of the Labour Party had become to feel disenfranchised within the Labour Party. The success of Labour's most successful electoral period in the 1990s and 2000s, as Blairism dominated, meant the left were often treated as tokenistic. This battle between ideology and electability has long been part of the Labour Party internal struggles, going back to Ramsey MacDonald in the 1920s. To further add to the left's troubles, was a clear lack of way forward for the socialist-wing following the end of the Soviet Union leaving the radical left across Europe a movement in search of an ideology (March and Mudde, 2005). A lack of clear ideology in the left, resulted in the European radical left largely settling on embracing a populist view of social and economic issues (Rooduijn and Akkerman, 2015).

This change in the left's ideology may have had little impact within the Labour Party if it wasn't for the opening up of the party to more internal democracy in the 2010s. As seen in Chapter 2, both the Conservative and Labour's parties began to open up its internal democracy in the 1990s, however this shift became more radical in the Labour Party than in the Conservative Party in 2012, following a controversy in the Falkirk West constituency.

In Falkirk West it emerged the Unite union had aimed to influence the selection of the 2015 Labour candidate. This led Labour leader Ed Miliband to abolish the Electoral College system of electing a Labour Leader - taking away the unions vote. Miliband initiated a OMOV (one member, one vote) system to reduce Union power; while also encouraging new members to join by reducing the membership fees to join (Quinn, 2016; Denham and Dorey; 2016). The reforms mandated any MP running for leadership needed 15% of the Parliamentary Labour Party's (PLP) signature to be nominated. Once passed the 15% threshold, the candidate would face a simple preferential vote from members and affiliated supporters to determine who would be leader. These reforms saw general support within the Labour Party, however little thought seems to have been given to the potential ramifications of opening up of the party.

The role of the Unions in the Labour Party is interesting to consider. The introduction of the electoral college in 1993 gave the unions a large amount of voting power. They had typically used this to limited effect until 2010 with the election of Miliband (Jobson and Wickham-Jones, 2011) yet the introduction of the OMOV system allowed any member of an affiliated trade union to register to vote in the leadership election for free. Yet despite fears of huge influence of the unions (Wintour, 2015), the democratisation of the Labour Party saw a reduction in their power (Wickham-Jones, 2015).

Corbyn's Ideology

Jeremy Corbyn's career as a backbencher was to a large extent tossed aside upon the start of the 2015 Leadership election. He had spent much of his time as a backbencher focusing on issues that were rarely mentioned throughout the campaign such as: nuclear disarmament, support for a United Ireland, and support for autocratic left-wing regimes abroad (Kellner, 2015c). The initial thrust of his campaign was about restoring the halcyon days of the Attlee government and the 'golden age' of Labour as a movement rather than political party (Watts and Bale, 2018). He promised these reforms by allowing more internal democracy to allow easier deselection and by relying on an 'anti-process and anti-institutional stance' (Watts and Bale 2018; 109). Corbyn's overall politics 'ideology' was based on the simplification of issues. There were no problems that could not be blamed on the neo-liberal Labour Party, the Conservative Party, or global capitalism.

The unconventional nature of Corbyn's populism: his lack of emotive charisma, his intra-party focus, and nature as a political 'maverick'; has led Dean and Maiguashca (2017) to argue Corbyn should not be seen as a populist. His attempts to discuss social inequality and move against New Labour's neoliberalism were genuine attempts at changing the direction of the party, not a populist backlash. Secondly they argue Corbyn aimed to highlight a 'crisis of representation' rather than a sense of aggrievement that genuine populists often employ. Thirdly, they argue that Corbyn does not have the 'populist styling' of Wilders or Le Pen, and that the 'Corbynmania' surrounding him was a form of political fandom (reminiscent of the 'Milifandom' that surrounded Ed Miliband during the 2015 general election) rather than a cult like focus on 'the leader.' However Dean and Maiguashca understate Corbyn's charisma and personal styling. He does not use the vituperative rhetoric of more radical populists, yet his image of 'anti-charisma' matches his anti-politics (Rentoul, 2015). His strand of populism is further anglicized with his left-wing style of populism being imbued in a British socialist tradition George Orwell characterised as 'sandals and pistachio coloured shirts...vegetarian, teetotaler and creeping Jesus' (Orwell, 2018 [1937]; 201). Dean and Maiguashca oversimplify populism by only limiting it to the more radical populisms. Populisms form in each country varies depending on the political culture and structure (Worsley, 1969). The argument of this dissertation, is not that Corbyn is akin to the more radical populisms of Europe or South America; but that he represents a unique British form of populism shaped by the party structure.

Corbyn's rule breaking and breaking of political norms is highly comparable to other populists. Corbyn's career is characterised by a series of controversies that would defeat a more mainstream politician. Many supporters saw this as evidence of Corbyn's 'purity' in supporting the hardest hit

economically and his campaigns for social justice. Yet Corbyn's ability to cast himself as a moralistic bellwether inside the Labour Party despite close relations and tacit support for Hamas, Hezbollah, and the IRA would have defeated a more mainstream candidate. Additionally, Corbyn's focus on campaigning for social justice did not stop him working for Iranian Press TV, and finding himself in regular contact with Holocaust deniers and anti-Semites (Bloodworth, 2015). For many Corbyn supporters, this focus on Corbyn's political activities and past dealings only added to their view that the 'mainstream' was out to 'get' Corbyn. This is supplemented by a broader relationship between populism and conspiracy. Watts and Bale (2018, 107) noted that 'conspiracy theories and their use within left-populism also have a clear link with Trotskyist thinking, which tends to emphasise the conspiratorial nature of elite rule, and – on the extreme fringes anyway – even the antisemitism of which some in Corbyn's Labour Party have recently been accused.'

Yet what Corbyn also represented was a level of popularity with voting ordinary members of the Labour Party that was unmatched by any other candidate. By arguing for a different Labour Party and country, the members liked that Corbyn was different and unique. Corbyn was able to use long standing tensions and the opening up of the party to catapult himself into power.

The Leadership Election process

The 2015 general election was largely a disaster and led to resignation of Ed Miliband. The subsequent leadership election saw a wide-array of candidates to follow Miliband. Andy Burnham and Yvette Cooper represented the social democratic wing; Liz Kendall the Blairite wing; and the left-wing Jeremy Corbyn. Corbyn had been a backbench MP since 1983 with no front bench experience and little support from his own party (Watts and Bale, 2018), and was 'generally despised within the Labour establishment' (Parker and Pickard, 2015).

Upon entering the race Corbyn's campaigning focused less on policy and more broadly about trying to reform the party by 'embracing the 'authentic' voice of Labour members,' (Watts and Bale, 2018; 103). The initial spur of Corbynism was self-consciously focusing on the Labour Party itself, and returning power 'to the members,' – a piece of rhetoric similar to 'the people'. Labour's recent electoral defeats, Corbyn argued, were because Labour needed to become more authentically left-wing and re-embrace Labour as a 'movement', rather than a political party (Corbyn, 2015a).

Corbyn's rally in Liverpool in July 2015, shows what the initial campaign was focused on. Corbyn talks about 'developing the movement' rather than a policy platform in being the key in how to win the next general election (Corbyn, 2015b). This was not a candidacy to prove his chances against the Conservative Party at the next general election; it was a candidacy of general disillusionment within the left of the Labour Party. Corbyn's aims were to change the Labour Party away from its long term position described as a 'party of modest social reform in a capitalist system' (Miliband, 1964; 376).

The election instantly began to develop a strong 'Corbynista' brand of politics. His use of terms like 'comrade,' and rhetoric of the Labour left from the 1970s was instructive as to how he wanted the membership to see his candidacy. Not as the way forward, but to glory days. The initial aim of the campaign was to improve the radical left movement's position in, and not the overall electoral health of, the Labour Party.

Denham, Dorey, and Roe-Crines (2020; 210) highlight Corbyn's second campaign rally in Liverpool, a month later, as a crucial turning point. By this point the polls had shown Corbyn as favourite (Kellner, 2015a), and Corbyn's main message had moved on. His attacks were still highlighting his anti-establishment in Labour, but now had broadened his attacks to include the Westminster elites. His campaign was not concerned with broadening his base by moderating his voice: it was a populist movement within the Labour Party. Far from backroom discussion and Parliamentary tussles, it had turned into an open primary contest within the Labour Party and the left was winning.

This primary feel of the contest was a further accentuated by Corbyn's supporters ferocity on social media. Many of Corbyn's supporters first political activism often centred around the Occupy Movement 2010-2011 (Dean and Maiguashca, 2017; 149-150), which added impetus to the campaign beyond the typical Labour Party leadership contest. Corbyn supporters spread internet memes, rigged social media polls and had high levels of engagement with Corbyn-related articles; which all led to a general sense of 'momentum' within the campaign (Denham, Dorey, and Roe-Crines, 2020; 211).

The role of the 'Momentum', a decentralised political movement pushing Corbyn's agenda, was perhaps overestimated. From May, 2015, just after the general election 94,000 new members and 115,000 affiliated supporters joined and allowed to vote (Seyd, 2020). However, even counting only Labour members before the May election, Corbyn still gained 54% of the vote (Kellner, 2015b). Corbyn was still the victorious candidate in the pre-Momentum party.

Corbyn's Intra-Party Populism

That populism in Britain had not manifested itself in a similar form as in Europe and Latin America, has been due to the strong two-party system and party elites control of the leadership process. For much of the Labour Party's recent history, the main competition for political control came from the Conservative Party so there was a reliance on Stark's (1996) maxims on acceptability, competence and electability in how a prospective leader should be elected (see chapter 2), as power was the ultimate aim for the parliamentary party. The change to a grassroots elected leader resulted in a different desire for the members: they chose on ideological grounds (Kellner, 2015a). Corbyn used nascent populist feelings on the left and dedicated himself to empowering the membership. Yet in policy terms Corbynism was not as radical as some make out. The move leftwards had begun under Miliband (Blackburn, 2015). What marked Corbyn's victory as unique was the way he went about

doing so, and his attempts to change the party to a movement via the support of his 'heartland' (Watts and Bale, 2018).

The Corbyn victory represents two distinct elements of populism as an intra-party phenomenon: it was a victory of populism about the Labour Party. Originally a tokenistic candidate, Corbyn's aim was to rouse a dormant and disenfranchised Labour grouping of left-wingers so Corbyn could implement a new style of politics. This was the view that members should control the Labour Party and that the Parliamentary Party was obedient to the members wishes. Corbyn's aim was the undermining of the Burkean notion of the representational MP, in favour of a party of delegates selected by the Labour membership. This party populism instantly catapulted him to the polling lead, which allowed him to turn his voice towards the country at large, which started much of the Momentum campaign. Corbyn's attacks against a neo-liberal Labour Party, needing to become less a party and more a movement to protect the poor against globalisation and capitalism, was a radical departure from the political norm.

To conclude, the Corbyn case study pushes the case for seeing British populism in an intra-party perspective. Corbyn throughout his long career, was never able nor likely to spin-off and create or join a different party – the intra-party approach was the only one. The broad ideological melting pots that British mainstream parties represent are their strength in maintaining a two-party system, yet was also how Corbyn became leader of the opposition. These jostling fractions inside the Labour Party would previously have had to settle on a candidate who was ideological acceptable for all; yet the change in leadership selection meant the members could choose who they wanted: and they wanted Corbyn.

Chapter 4: The Conservative Party

There can be no doubt that the 2019 Conservative Party leadership election represented ‘the future’ for the Conservative Party after the 2016 referendum to leave the European Union. The calling of the Brexit referendum was interwoven with the rise of populism in the Conservative Party. Yet the difference between Corbyn and Johnson was that Johnson was not only to be elected leader, but also Prime Minister. One might have expected that this would mollify the Conservative Party members, yet evidence suggests that due to the failures of the Labour Party under Corbyn, the members were more blasé about the threat from Labour, and more concerned about the Brexit Party and the Conservative Party’s inability to get Brexit done.

Chapter 4 will argue the following:

- The Conservative Party has seen a dramatic change in its party structure similar to the Labour Party, allowing Johnson the opportunity to win the 2019 leadership election
- Johnson was a typical populist in his ability to leverage a ‘crisis’ in the shape of Brexit to push his own agenda
- Johnson’s populism is difficult to define, due to his lack of firm ideology.
- Johnson was popular before his strong turn towards populism (The relationship between popularity and being a populist is not well understood).

Conservative Party Background

This rise of populism in modern times in the Conservative Party can be traced back to the success of UKIP at the 2014 European elections (Lazaridi and Tsagkroni, 2016; Bale, 2018). The threat of UKIP however was overblown. Going into the 2015 General Election, the EU was ranked as only the 11th most important voting factor (Hay, 2020).

There had long been a populist streak in the Conservatives party, especially with regard to Europe and immigration (Bale, 2013); however this was kept to the fringes with the Conservative Party historically less ideological than the Labour Party (Seyd, 1987; 3). The Conservative party had historically always been able to manage the party by moving to the backbenches any senior MP who

was seen as too radical, such as Churchill in the 1930s over India and Appeasement (Roberts, 2019; 348-350) and Enoch Powell over multiculturalism (see Denham, Dorey, Roe-Crines, 2020; 44-47).

Yet this challenge from the right in the form of UKIP resulted in a pledge by David Cameron before the 2015 election to hold a referendum, should they win a majority (Schnapper, 2015). The vote to leave the European Union was populist from the beginning with 'taking back control' from Brussels, and a sop to the nostalgia of 1950s Britain being the emotive issues that propelled the campaign (Hay, 2020). Following the referendum, Brexit became the all-consuming issue in the Conservative Party. Yet even with the subsequent vote to leave and the May government's best attempts to leave, Theresa May was never enough of a populist to push through what in effect a populist project. Her inability to define what a 'May Brexit' would look like, made May a dead woman walking for much of her time at Number 10 (Gamble, 2018).

May's floundering led to a clear surge in 2019 of right-wing populism that the Conservative Party struggled to gain. At the 2019 European elections, the Conservative Party finished 5th nationally behind both Nigel Farage's Brexit Party. For the first time, the Conservative Party saw its primary challenge not from centre, but from the right (Cutts et al., 2019). The day after the European and local elections, Theresa May signalled her intent to resign as leader.

The Leadership Election

Following May's resignation, the subsequent leadership election was far less dramatic than in the Labour Party, with Boris Johnson always favourite. A shortlist of candidates would be whittled down to two by the Parliamentary Party, with the two remaining candidates facing the membership. There was some speculation Johnson tried to manipulate the final vote tally to ensure Jeremy Hunt rather than Michael Gove faced him in the membership vote, as Gove was seen as the better debater (Denham, Dorey, P and Roe-Crines, 2020; Elliott, F., Wright, O. and Zeffman, 2019). This, however, was still a long way off the backroom dealings that occurred when the 'magic circle' selected the leader.

The fact that Johnson was the most popular candidate with the membership may not have meant a great deal pre-1998 reforms. The parliamentary party by itself would have chosen a candidate that adhered to Stark's (1996) criteria for acceptance, electability and competence; and most likely passed over Johnson. However with the membership having the final say, this changed the incentives of MPs to select a candidate more likely to win membership support.

The membership vote, decided by the 160,000 Conservative Party members, was far more ideological than previous cohorts. The primary aim for the membership was getting Brexit done, with the electoral challenge of the Brexit Party and Jeremy Corbyn only secondary concerns (Smith, 2019). Johnson was chosen as he best represented what the membership wanted, and in their opinion, what the country wanted too.

It is here where Johnson's ability to convince the membership to vote for somebody who was not the best electoral candidate nor the most acceptable to broad swathes of the Conservative Party. It was Johnson's personal appeal and charisma that allowed him to bat away any hard questions about his competence.

Johnson repeatedly promised that if selected, he would leave the EU on 31st October 2019 without a withdrawal deal if necessary. In other words, Johnson's claim that he was the only one who could 'leave on the 31st October' if selected (Proctor, 2019) was his campaign surmised in a sentence. It was a calculated gamble from Johnson, informed by his previous political experience of how different rules applied to him. His campaign could be focused on a single issue: Brexit. Previous leadership races, even when going before the membership, had been a battle over Stark's criteria, for the winner.

Using Stark's criteria for selecting a leader, Jeremy Hunt would have been the more sensible choice for leader. Hunt was more acceptable to more of the Parliamentary Party with a more moderate ideology. Hunt had also been a long standing cabinet minister and while not universally liked, compared favourably to Johnson's poor showing in his time as foreign minister. Hunt's more centrist position also meant the electorate at large preferred him to Johnson (Walker, 2019).

Since re-entering Parliament in 2015, Boris Johnson's politics had taken a decisively more populist bent. Johnson's political style has been constantly evolving since his days as a prominent backbencher where his constant media presence belied any real political achievements. However the Brexit referendum hardened Johnson's political image, as his message moved further to the political right compared to his time as Mayor of London (2008-2016).

Due to higher aspirations, Johnson's time as Mayor did not see the same level of populist styling as the post-referendum Johnson (Worthy, et al., 2018). However the nature of the Mayor's office lends itself to Johnson style of 'overly candid political maverick' (Edwards and Isaby, 2008; 44), something Johnson shared with his predecessor Ken Livingston. The competition from political arenas other than Parliament is perhaps an underexplored region of British politics, yet Johnson was able to use the position to good effect and establish himself as a 'celebrity politician' (Wood, Corbett and Flinders, 2016).

It was this image of 'being Boris Johnson' that appealed to the membership during the leadership election process (Castle, 2019), not his ideology. Boris Johnson's charisma Flinders (2020) labelled as 'populist playfulness' appealed to many in both the Conservatives grassroots and the general electorate. Like with Corbyn, there was a growing demand for politicians to be a 'normal person' (Wood, Corbett and Flinders, 2016).

Part of the difficulty in the analysis of Johnson's populism is in trying to ascertain some overall ideology. Some have tried to define Johnson's ideology as broadly as 'Merry England conservatism' (Gimson 2016; 299), others like Purnell (2012) have argued his political beliefs lack any real substance. Since the Brexit referendum Johnson's rhetoric has moved further to the right, however Purnell is perhaps the most accurate. The best way to describe Johnson's political ideology is by seeing it as broadly free of ideology. Johnson's career is described largely not by a political ideology, but by trying to be popular.

Johnson's populism is as much directed to boost his own popularity, rather than in service of any broader political ideology. Small policy details are not as important as appearing to be popular with the people. During and following the Brexit referendum Johnson's move to a right-wing populist was more identifiable not in speeches, but in his newspaper columns. A journalist before entering

politics, Johnson's *Daily Telegraph* column highlights the lack of overall ideology and over simplification of many issues. Johnson's columns are more interested in whipping up issues to elicit an emotive reaction. As Canovan (1984; 313) argues, populist actors use a 'rhetorical style which relies heavily upon appeals to the people.' Johnson's columns emphasise the 'common sense' of his readers and relied on issues like the Northern Ireland-Republic of Ireland border, post Brexit, comparing it to the logistics of NASA's moon landing (Johnson, 2019a), or calling for stronger law to stop drug dealers 'going on spa breaks' (Johnson, 2019b).

Furthermore, Johnson's use of terms like 'bumboys' to describe Peter Mandelson or 'piccaninnies' to describe Africans is both jarring and odd. A long-serving politician like Johnson would know the likelihood of this type of language being brought up. Yet Johnson has consistently refused to apologise for this type of language (Sky News, 2018). In addition it was using this politics of emotion that enabled Johnson to emphasise a sense of 'betrayal' regarding the Brexit debacle. This language chimed with a membership whose main political desire was for a quick Brexit (Smith, 2019). During the leadership campaign, Johnson leveraged the 'need' for Brexit to his leadership campaign by using this type of emotive language. With this language and 'buffoonery and pantomime antics' (Flinders, 2020), Johnson was able to mask a deeper political strategy other politicians struggled to compete with.

Johnson's success as a populist can be summed up into three main elements: his ability to dominate the narrative through soundbites and slogans that tapped into long-standing politician dissatisfaction; his strange mix of classically informed rhetoric and 'pantomime antics' (Flinders, 2020) that made him a unique figure in British politics; and his status as one of the few genuinely household names in politics.

Intra-Party Populism

Despite Johnson's general popularity within the membership, if the leadership selection was only chosen by the Parliamentary Party then Johnson would not have been selected. As Denham, Dorey and Roe-Crines (2020) show, the favourite for the Conservative Party election has often been defeated due to back room discussions, as issues like acceptability to the Parliamentary Party were brought up. William Whitelaw in 1975, Michael Heseltine in 1990, Kenneth Clarke in 1997 all failed

to win the nomination despite being an early favourite. When Kenneth Clarke was again passed over in 2001 by the membership in favour of Iain Duncan Smith, it marked a change.

When Smith was elected in 2001, he was chosen by the membership for 'acceptability on ideological or policy grounds' (Denham, Dorey and Roe-Crines, 2020; 94). The ideological vote was the key factor influencing Conservatives outside Parliament. We can see this with Johnson too. The clear support of the membership for Johnson changed the Conservative Party, into needing to present a candidate in ideological agreement. For the Parliamentary Party, the backing of Johnson during the campaign was a safe bet in supporting the winning side - especially for ambitious younger MPs.

The success of Johnson's populism should not be underestimated. While there was a clear upsurge in populist feeling, the level of support for Johnson's populism within the party was highly motivated by his populist turn since leaving the Mayoralty in 2016. Less remembered by his supporters was his poor spell as foreign minister from 2016-2018, which by other politicians standards would have seen a permanent move to the backbenches.

The similarities between the Conservative and Labour Party leadership contests show how populism operates within the party system but also how it can have a radical impact on the Party. In Corbyn's case, his populism was aimed at both the Labour Party and the more general political structures. Johnson's populism during the campaign took aims at the party too, with his attacks on inability of the party to 'get Brexit done' (Proctor, 2019).

Johnson's victory represents in some respects a similar victory to that of Corbyn, however Johnson's victory was no upset. He was favourite, but the clear rightward turn of the Conservative Party grassroots played a large part of that popularity. In some respects, it is surprising it took as long as 22 years for the first populist Conservative Party leader with the party always having populist elements, yet the members were content with a leader who fulfilled the Stark criteria until 2019.

Johnson's populism is a mix of some proto-typical populist characteristics: his overemphasis of crises, his use of language, his reference to 'the people', and his use of emotive language in his newspaper columns has pushed Johnson into populist territory. The main issue Johnson raises is how to address his clear popularity, and how it relates to populism. Johnson had long been popular before his more populist turn. This taxonomical limits of the 'populist' label is unclear when distinguishing between 'what is a populist' and 'how politicians become popular'.

Conclusion: The Future of Populism In Britain

This dissertation had argued for an intra-party model when it comes to studying populism in Britain. The difference in Britain, is the party structure and political system in comparison to many European and Latin American countries. This intra-party populism has resulted in two key findings about the nature of intra-party populism: it is both an attempt to change the party; and then the country. The growth of populism within parties over the last decade has been profound and little understood. The election of Jeremy Corbyn in 2015 was seen as remarkable at the time, yet there was little attempt at understanding the broader historical significance of the victory. The same can be said of Johnson.

This growth in populism over recent years is never linear. Populism always comes in waves at times of high emotion and political discontent. The most recent Labour Leadership election in 2020 was won by moderate Keir Starmer. To some this may undermine this notion of intra-party populism, as Starmer won the leadership election as a moderate centre-left candidate using the same selection rules as Corbyn. Yet this would be misunderstanding of the intra-populism theory. It is not that parties will face a constant battle with populist insurgencies, or that the parties will be turned broadly into populist parties, it is that the opening up of party democracy has reoriented the parties more towards the grassroots, which under the right circumstance could lead to populist insurgency. If a new populist wave hits Labour, this intra-party populism may once again rise.

The nature of the intra-party populist is different to the inter-party populist. Intra-party populism has a focus on the parties themselves; arguing the party is off-track and needs to recalibrate. Both Johnson and Corbyn were highly focused on their respective parties and how they had gone off track. What in effect the intra-party populism in Britain represented, was a change in political style and how to approach to politics.

Johnson and Corbyn's political style was to use rhetoric uncommon in mainstream politics. Johnson was less concerned with upsetting previous Conservative Party positions, and making his opposition to the May leadership clear. Furthermore, Johnson emphasized the need for Brexit and a refusal to apologise or modify his brand of politics (Mason, 2019; BBC News, 2019). Corbyn meanwhile

emphasised a clear break with the current party by embracing the language and styling of a 1970s style British socialist. Much of his rhetoric and approach to the campaign was based upon this conception of a Labour Party gone wrong, Corbyn's approach was simply aimed to highlight this.

The process of intra-party democracy has been a mini-democratic revolution in itself. The growth of democracy in parties has meant that parties have had to respond. The nature of political parties, as Michels (1915) highlights, means that oligarchies in social organisations will always rise, but the growth in democracy in parties means they can be broken up far easier. The growth of Corbyn as Labour leader and subsequent entrenchment, followed by Starmer's ability to break the populist left stranglehold over the party shows how easy it is for fast and radical change in parties. The Conservative Party's internal democracy is less open than Labour's, yet it has still shifted the party. In 2001, Iain Duncan Smith was preferred by the membership over Ken Clarke, yet it was the election of Johnson that was the first big shift of the Conservative Party's leadership reforms, allowing the members to choose the new way forward.

What does this conception of British populism represent for the future of democracy? The first is the growth of intra-party democracy. The expansion of democratic pluralism within the parties is a radical shift in the British political model. The general franchise had long been extended to all, yet parties remained somewhat closed off from the public. Seyd (2019) has argued that the opening up of parties is not a positive step due to the damage for the representational aspect of Parliamentary democracy. Yet democracy is about trusting the demos to make the best decisions. If party democracy is to succeed in Britain, it needs safety in numbers by an increase in party membership to stop insurgency. Low levels of party members contrasts with their increasing power, and moving large amounts of political power towards a self-selecting few in the grassroots. This is not a positive move for an open democracy. Furthermore, the low level of membership and the potential for social media groups or older political movements to enter into the party to extract gains will remain with current membership numbers in the low 100,000s.

However, British populism tends to be more moderate than elsewhere because of the nature of needing to be a 'political maverick', due to the political system. Something that is not a feature of European populism. In Britain, the rise of this intra-party populism is not a rejection of politics as it is elsewhere, but a symptom of discontent with status quo politics. Change is inevitable in democracies, that should be taken as a norm; yet what both Corbyn and Johnson tapped into was tiredness of the status quo and a desire to see 'real people' in Parliament.

Populism can be dangerous. It can unleash rhetoric and changes to political systems that have a profound damage. But intra-party populism does not work against the system like in most populisms; it disrupts the system but works with the system to enact change. There is a clear moderation that intra-party populism initiates. To be clear all populism is dangerous, playing with populism is the political equivalent of playing with fire (Flinders, 2017; 233). Yet in Britain, this dissertation has highlighted what might ironically be called 'mainstream populism', and how it can have great change on a political culture through an intra-party mechanism.

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